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Compulsory unethical pro-organisational behaviour and employees' in-role performance: a moderated mediation analysis

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This study aimed to identify the influences of compulsory unethical pro-organisational behaviour (CUPB) on employees' in-role performance and the potential mechanisms between them. Based on the multilevel data from 612 salespeople in China (female = 55.4%; managers = 47.8%; 23–30 years = 55.2%), we found that CUPB was associated with lower employees' in-role performance. Guilty emotion partially mediated the relationship between CUPB and employees' in-role performance. Further, we found that the strength between CUPB and guilty emotion was moderated by moral identity. Specially, the regression analysis results showed that the CUPB–moral identity interaction effect significantly predicted feeling guilty. However, the moderated mediation effect of moral identity was not significant. Our results suggest a need for businesses not to force employees too much, to avoid employees engaging in compulsory UPB, and to carefully evaluate both the positive and negative effects of UPB.

Keywords: compulsory unethical pro-organisational behaviour, CUPB, guilty, in-role performance, moral identity

Introduction

Umphress and colleagues (2010) coined the term "unethical pro-organisational behaviour" (UPB) to refer to "actions that are intended to promote the effective functioning of the organisation or its members and violate core societal values, mores, laws, or standards of proper conduct" (p.622). It has also been assumed that UPB is an active and voluntary behaviour. Yet, this might not be the case in some work settings. In fact, several scholars noted that individuals engage in UPBs because they are often confronted with pressure from a variety of sources (Chen & Liang, 2017; Li et al., 2018; Mesdaghinia, 2019; Wang et al., 2021a) or the behaviours are rewarded by the organisation in forms of job retention, positive performance evaluation, raises, bonuses, and promotions (Tian & Peterson, 2016). Moreover, many studies focused on the antecedents of UPB (Chen, et al., 2016; Ebrahimi & Yurtkoru, 2017; Miao et al., 2013; Umphress & Bingham, 2011) and not its consequences or the mechanisms behind its occurrence. Consistent with these scholars, Wang and colleagues (2021a) proposed the concept of compulsory unethical pro-organisational behaviour (CUPB) based on self-determination theory. As a new research area, the consequences of CUPB have not been well explored. Our study aimed to explore guilty emotion as a mechanism in CUPBs in the Chinese context; thereby providing leads for further studies.

CUPB: an emergent construct

CUPB emerged with the purpose of increasing the effective functioning of the organisation or its members (i.e., organisational performance) under some kind of pressure (e.g., performance pressure, ethical pressure). In spite of the original purpose of CUPB, little is known about the influence of it on job performance, leading to some important questions going unanswered: (i) Does CUPB really improve job performance? and (ii) If so, what are the underlying mechanisms? This study sought to responds to calls in the literature to examine the consequences of UPB on a more dynamic basis as well as to identify factors that influence the degree to which CUPB is beneficial or costly for job performance.

CUPB and in-role performance

In-role performance is an important construct in the field of job performance. It refers to a series of direct actions performed by employees at a specific work position. Different from extra-role performance, in-role performance focus on formal tasks, duties, and responsibilities which are included in job descriptions (Willams & Anderson, 1991). Employees' CUPB emerges in response to external pressures put on by their leaders or co-workers. Employees who interpret this kind of behaviour in a negative manner are expected to respond negatively in terms of their behaviours and attitudes (Vigoda-Gadot, 2007).

Cognitive dissonance theory (Festinger, 1957) might explain the relationship between CUPB and in-role performance. According to cognitive dissonance theory, when employees are asked to engage in activities that are inconsistent with or even contrary to their attitudes, they seek a stable state in which the dissonance can be minimised by changing behaviours, changing attitudes, or adding new consonant cognitions (Festinger, 1957). Prior studies found that when employees are forced to engage in behaviours that benefit the organisation, they will have a sense of psychological dissonance and tend to reduce their work efforts and work hours (Samnani et al., 2014; Vigoda-Gadot, 2007; Xia & Wang, 2018; Zhao, 2014). This may be explained by associated feelings of guilt for violating basic morally.

The mediating role of guilty emotion

As an inherent component of organisational life, moral emotion has attracted growing research attention. Guilt is a typical moral emotion. It is a negative emotional experience

generated when individuals evaluate their own or others' behaviours or thoughts according to certain moral standards. People who feel guilty believe that their actions harmed others or violated moral rules and that they should be held responsible for their actions. According to affective events theory (AET: Weiss & Cropanzano, 1996), work events can trigger an individual's emotional response, which in turn changes the individual's subsequent attitude and behaviours. Specifically, positive events cause positive emotions and positive behaviours, while negative events cause negative emotions and negative behaviours. CUPB, as a forced behaviour, may be viewed as a negative event by employees. Some scholars argued that guilt might be the possible emotional consequence of UPB (Umphress & Bingham, 2011). Therefore, we propose that CUPB can trigger feelings of guilt and lead to reduced job performance.

The moderating role of moral identity

Moral identity refers to the extent to which one values being a moral person and is "a self-conception organised around a set of moral traits (e.g., honesty, kindness, compassion)" (Aquino & Reed, 2002, p. 1424). In the view of scholars, moral identity is a stable individual-variable (Aquino & Reed, 2002; Chen & Liang, 2017). Individuals with high moral identity will expand the scope of their own ethical thinking and tend to promote human welfare. If they are forced to do what is good for their organisations ar the expense of external stakeholders (e.g., consumers, competitors), they will feel guilty and blame themselves for their actions. In contrast, individuals with low morality pay more attention to how to fulfil the task requirements by the leaders and ignore the groups outside their organisations and are more likely to interpret their own behaviours as legitimate behaviours under the orders of authority. Accordingly, we propose that individuals with a high moral identity are more likely to feel guilty after practicing CUPB and lower their job performance, while those with a low moral identity are less likely to feel guilty.

Goal of the study

Our study examined the influence of CUPB on employees' in-role performance via guilty emotions. We also sought to explore the influence of moral identity in this relationship. Based on our conceptual framework depicted in Figure 1, we tested the following hypotheses:

- H_1 CUPB will be associated with lower in-role performance of employees.
- H_2 CUPB will be associated with higher guilty emotions among employees.
- H_3 Guilty emotion will mediate the association between CUPB and employees' in-role performance, reducing employees' in-role performance.
- H_4 Moral identity moderates the relationship between CUPB and guilty emotion, such that the relationship strengthens when moral identity is high.
- H_5 Moral identity moderates the indirect relationship between CUPB and in-role performance through guilty emotion, such that the indirect relationship strengthens when moral identity is high.

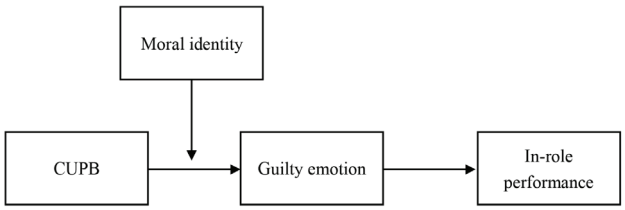


Figure 1. Research model describing the hypothesised links between CUPB, guilty emotion, in-role performance, and moral identity

Method

Participants and setting

Data were collected from full-time employees in several sales company in the southwest of China. The final study sample consisted of 612 employees (female = 55.4%), and most were between 23 to 30 years old (55.2%). In terms of education, 71.2% of the participants had a bachelor's degree. A significant minority had working experience of 2 to 4 years with their organisations, and 70.3% of the participants worked 8–12 hours a day.

Measures

CUPB

At Time 1, we measured CUPB using a 7-item scale developed by Wang and colleagues (2021a). The scale is a 7-point scale ranging from 1 = never, to 7 = more than once a day. Sample items include: "had to mispresent the truth to make your organisation look good"; "I had to ignore the rights and interests of people outside the organisation under certain pressures"; and "I had to highlight the advantages of your product or service and avoid the disadvantages under certain pressure." In the present study, the Cronbach's alpha value for scores from the CUPB was 0.81.

Guilty Emotion (GM)

At Time 2, we measured guilty emotion using a 3-item scale, developed by Izard and colleagues (1974) and used by Tang and colleagues (2020) in a similar setting as the current study. Participants were asked to indicate how often they experienced these emotions over the past 30 days on a 7-point scale ranging from 1 = never, to 7 = always. Sample items include: "repentant"; "guilty"; and "blameworthy". In the present study, the scales obtained an α of 0.79.

In-role performance (IRP)

At Time 2, in-role performance was assessed using the 7-item scale developed by Williams and Anderson (1991). A sample item includes: "I meet formal performance requirements of the job." Responses are scored on a 7-point scale ranging from 1 = strongly disagree, to 7 = strongly agree. In the present study, the reliability of scores from the IRP scale was 0.80.

Moral identity

At Time 1, we measured moral identity (MI) using a 5-item scale validated by Aquino and Reed (2002). Sample items include: "It would make me feel good to be a person who has these characteristics"; and "Being someone who has

these characteristics is an important part of who I am". Responses are scored on a 7-point scale ranging from 1 = strongly disagree, to 7 = strongly agree. In the present study, reliability of scores from the MI scale was 0.80.

Control variable

We controlled for employees' age, gender, tenure, and job position (0 = non-management, 1 = management; Umphress et al., 2011), since prior studies found these demographic characteristics may be related to unethical behaviour (Wang et al. 2021b).

Procedure

The Ethical Committee of the Department of Management Zunyi Medical University approved the study (ethics number: 20220616). Participants individually consented to the research with our assurances of the confidentiality of the data they provided. Additionally, we included a cover letter which indicated that participation was voluntary.

All the surveys were conducted via the Internet across two time periods. At Time 1, we measured CUPB, moral identity, demographic information, and control variables. At Time 2 (one week later), we measured guilty emotion and in-role performance.

Data analysis

To examine our predictions, we first conducted a confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) with AMOS 23.0 to verify the distinctiveness of the measurement model. Thereafter, we computed moderated mediation examination with the PROCESS macros version 3 (Hayes, 2015) using SPSS.

Table 1 presents the results of CFA for this study. It indicated that the four-factor model (with CUPB, guilty emotion, in-role performance, and moral identity as four independent factors) yield a better model fit (χ^2/df = 2.73, CFI = 0.95, TLI = 0.94, SRMR = 0.04, RMSEA = 0.05), which was superior to all the alternative models. These results demonstrate that the four focus variables could be clearly distinguished.

Results

Descriptive statistics and correlations

Table 2 presents the means, standard deviations, correlations, and reliability coefficients for all variables. As expected, we found a significant positive correlation between CUPB and feeling guilty ($r = 0.14$, $p < 0.01$), and a significant negative correlation between CUPB and in-role performance ($r = -0.11$, $p < 0.01$).

Predicting in-role performance from CUPB and guilty emotion

The hierarchical regression analysis (controlling for age, gender, tenure, and job position) results are presented in Table 3. As shown in model 5, we entered CUPB and in-role performance and found that CUPB was significantly negatively associated with in-role performance ($\beta = -0.10$, $p < 0.01$). Hence, Hypothesis 1 (CUPB will be associated with employees' lower in-role performance) was supported. For Hypothesis 2, we entered CUPB and feeling guilty and found that CUPB was positively related to feeling guilty ($\beta = 0.15$, $p < 0.001$). Thus, Hypothesis 2 (CUPB will be associated with employees' higher guilty emotions) was supported.

Guilty emotion mediation effect of CUPB on in-role performance

Further, we added both CUPB and feeling guilty to the regression analysis to test the mediating effect of feeling guilty. As presented in model 6, feeling guilty was negatively associated with in-role performance ($\beta = -0.25$, $p < 0.001$). However, the coefficient for CUPB became less

Table 1. Confirmatory factor analysis results

Model	χ^2	df	χ^2/df	CFI	TLI	SRMR	RMSEA
Four-factor model (M2): CUPB, guilty, IP, MI	191.10	70	2.73	0.95	0.94	0.04	0.05
Three-factor model (M3): CUPB, guilty+IP, MI	1 176.84	149	7.90	0.73	0.69	0.10	0.11
Two-factor model (M2): CUPB, guilty+IP+MI	1 913.48	151	12.67	0.54	0.48	0.14	0.14
Single-factor model (M1): All variables are combined into one factor	2 849.94	152	18.75	0.30	0.21	0.16	0.17

Note. $n = 612$; IP = in−role performance; MI = moral identification; CFI= Comparative Fit Index; TLI = Tucker Lewis Index; SRMR = Standardised Root Mean Square Residual; RMSEA = Root Mean Error of Approximation. Ideal model−fit indicators are: χ^2/df < 3, RMSEA < 0.08, CFI > 0.9, TLI > 0.9, SRMR < 0.08.

Table 2. Means, standard deviations, and intercorrelations of all variables

Variables	Mean	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1.Age	1.93	0.25	1							
2.Gender	1.45	0.50	−0.06	1						
3.Tenure	1.78	0.41	0.19**	0.05	1					
4.Job position	1.52	0.69	0.04	0.02	0.29**	1				
5.CUPB	3.36	0.86	0.09*	0.00	0.02	−0.09*	1			
6.Guilty	1.92	0.66	−0.02	0.02	−0.06	−0.01	0.14**	1		
7.IP	4.88	0.62	0.02	0.04	0.08	0.14**	−0.11**	−0.27**	1	
8.MI	4.77	0.57	0.01	−0.07	−0.01	−0.01	−0.09*	−0.1*	0.19**	1

Note. $n = 612$; IP = in−role performance; MI = moral identification; *$p < 0.05$, **$p < 0.01$, ***$p < 0.001$

significant ($\beta = -0.07$, $p > 0.05$). Thus, we can conclude that feeling guilty might completely mediate the effect of CUPB on in-role performance in accordance with Hypothesis 3.

Moreover, we conducted Haye's Process Program Model 4 to further evaluate the mediating effect of feeling guilty on the relationship between CUPB and in-role performance. The results of the bootstrapping analysis indicated that the indirect effect of CUPB on in-role performance through feeling guilty was significant ($B = -0.04$, 95% CI = [−0.662, −0.166], excluding zero). As a result, feeling guilty completely mediated the relationship between CUPB and in-role performance. The results support Hypothesis 3 (Guilty emotion will mediate the association between CUPB and employees' in-role performance, reducing employees' in-role performance).

Moral identity effects

Hypothesis 4 predicted that moral identity would moderate the relationship between CUPB and feeling guilty, such that the positive relationship between CUPB and feeling guilty would be stronger in higher moral identity than lower moral identity. As shown in Model 3 of Table 3, the CUPB–moral identity interaction effect significantly predicted feeling guilty ($\beta = 0.15$, $p < 0.001$). Therefore, the results support Hypothesis 4 (Moral identity moderates the relationship between CUPB and guilty emotion, such that the relationship strengthens when moral identity is high).

Hypothesis 5 stated that moral identity positively moderates the indirect effect of CUPB on in-role performance through feeling guilty. The moderated mediation effect was not significant (estimate = 0.01, $p > 0.05$, CI = [−0.0133, 0.0369]. Thus, Hypothesis 5 was not supported.

Discussion

We examined the effect of CUPB on in-role performance through guilty emotion and the moderating effect of moral identity on the relationship. All hypotheses were supported except Hypothesis 5. First, this study found CUPB to be associated with lower employee in-role performance. This is consistent to prior research which suggested the negative effect of compulsory citizenship behaviour on job performance (Zhao, 2014). According to Vigoda-Gadot (2007), employees are often forced to do what is good for the organisations. Different employees may interpret this contrarily. Those who interpret these pressures negatively may respond by lowering their job performance.

Second, we found guilty emotion to mediate the CUPB-in-role performance linkage. From an affective events theory perspective, CUPB will trigger negative emotional reactions which will further affect the individual's subsequent attitude and behaviour. In fact, prior studies proved that one's cognitive and behavioural experience will be limited when their negative emotions were strong (Grandey et al., 2004; Samnani et al., 2014), which will hinder the rapid mobilisation of individual cognitive resources and behavioural choices (Sun et al., 2021). That is, CUPB as a negative event in the workplace, brings about negative emotion, which in turn may lead to the decline of employees' job performance. Thus, our findings add to understanding the potential mediating mechanisms between UPCB and in-role performance.

Third, we found moral identity to moderate the relationship between CUPB and guilty emotion. Specially, when moral identity is high, the positive relationship between CUPB and feeling guilty will be stronger. However, when moral identity is low, the positive effect of CUPB on feeling guilty will be weakened. These findings are consistent with AET, which argues that individual trait factors related to an affective event at work can influence the emotional response and cognitive judgement of individuals (Sun et al., 2021; Weiss & Cropanzano, 1996). Specially, as a type of unethical behaviour, whether and how CUPB affects employees' negative emotions depends on how sensitive they are to other's emotions and how uncomfortable they feel after violating norms. That is, how they perceive the impact of taking unethical behaviour on their self-concept. The more sensitive employees are to the negative emotions of others, or the greater the impact of taking irrational behaviours on the positive self-concept of individuals, the more likely individuals will have negative emotions after taking such behaviours.

Implications for practice

This study has three practical implications. First, managers should put ethical goals in place when pursuing performance goals and profit goals. In real life, some managers see UPB as a way of loyalty to the organisation. Some employees must cater to the needs of the organisation or manager.

Table 3. Multiple regressions of hypothesised relationships

Variables	Guilty			In-role performance			
	Model 1	Model2	Model 3	Model 4	Model 5	Model 6	Model 7
Age	−0.01	−0.02	−0.02	0.01	0.02	0.01	0.02
Gender	0.02	0.02	0.02	0.03	0.03	0.04	0.03
Tenure	−0.07	−0.07	−0.07	0.04	0.04	0.03	0.04
Job position	0.01	0.02	0.01	0.12**	0.11**	0.12**	0.12**
CUPB		0.15***			−0.10**	−0.07	
Guilty						−0.25***	
CUPB*moral identity			0.15***				−0.07
R^2	0.01	0.03	0.03	0.02	0.03	0.09	0.02
ΔR^2	0.01	0.02***	0.02***	0.02*	0.01**	0.06***	0.02
F	0.68	3.12	3.26	3.32	4.01	10.51	3.20

Note. *$p < 0.05$, **$p < 0.01$, ***$p < 0.001$

Little do they know, this may not only harm the long-term development of the organisation, but also harm the actors of UPB themselves. In addition, by strengthening the moral management system within the enterprise, employees can be prevented from doing behaviours that are helpful to the organisation but harmful to external stakeholders. On the one hand, organisations should clarify their moral guidelines; and on the other hand, they could adopt ethically focused compensation systems and accountability mechanisms (Liu et al., 2021). By incorporating ethical standards directly into performance evaluations and explicitly rewarding ethical pro-organisational behaviour, organisations can send the right message to employees. Employees could understand what should and should not be done.

Second, our results suggest that CUPB might induce employee guilty emotion which further hinders job performance. Thus, managers need to conduct psychological counselling for employees to induce more positive emotions and improve their job performance.

Third, this study found that employees with a lower level of moral identity experienced fewer negative emotions after conducting UPB, and it was more difficult for them to realise the negative impact on themselves. Therefore, we suggest that human resource managers should pay more attention to employees' moral identity when recruiting new employees and in training programs on work-place ethics.

Limitations and future recommendations

Although this study collected data from different time points, it was still unable to draw conclusions about causality. Future studies can employ experimental methods or collect cross-lagged panel data to examine the causal relationship to provide more compelling evidence. In addition, CUPB should be widespread in a variety of sectors in diverse cultural contexts, but this study only collected data from sales sectors in the Chinese context. We strongly recommend that future studies collect data across work settings and cultures.

Conclusion

The finds of this study extend prior research on UPB in several important ways. First, this study responds to calls in the literature to examine the consequences of UPB, which confirm the existence of CUPB and assess its validity. Second, while UPB has typically been conceptualised as a good thing for organisations in the short-term, this study indicates that the pressure to engage in UPB can have some harmful outcomes for the actors themselves. Finally, employees' moral identity could affect how they interpret CUPB. In the long run, we should recruit individuals with higher levels of moral identity and avoid short-term behaviour.

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